

Division of Labour In Society

By Emile Durkheim

Division of Labour

Def :

Division of Labour is the separation of a work process into a number of tasks, with each task performed by a separate person or group of persons.

The specialisation of task is known as division of Labour.

Example :

Food production

A very basic example of division of labour could be seen in food gathering. In early societies, men would be the hunters, women and children would prepare the food and collect berries. The idea was that it was a very simple division of labour to enable the best use of different skill sets.

Factory

Workers, supervisor, manager

Government

PM, Home minister, Defense Minister

Division of Labour

Durkheim's first major work, *The Division of Labor in Society* (1893), which was based on his doctoral dissertation, Durkheim explains how the division of labor (or economic specialization) characteristic of modern society

Durkheim argued that economic specialization was not necessarily "bad" for either the individual or the society as a whole. Instead, he argued that an extensive division of labor could exist without necessarily jeopardizing the moral cohesion of a society or the opportunity for individuals to realize their interests affects individuals as well as society as a whole.

Durkheim's concept of the division of labor focused on the shift in societies from a simple society to one that is more complex. He argued that traditional societies were made up of homogenous people that were more or less the same in terms of values, religious beliefs, and backgrounds. Modern societies, in contrast, are made up of a complex division of labor, beliefs, and backgrounds.

In traditional societies, the collective consciousness ruled, social norms were strong, and social behavior was well regulated. In modern societies, common consciousness was less obvious, and the regulation of social behavior was less punitive and more restitutive, aiming to restore normal activity to society.

Emile Durkheim” belonged to the structural-functional school of thought. He was interested in the study of social structure and its functions. How different part of society function and contribute to the functioning of society as whole. He believed that social solidarity is the main element which hold society together. Social solidarity is the feeling of unity among individuals with one another and with society or what makes society solid, viable and hold it together. He explained solidarity in two different type of societies. He says that, mechanical solidarity exist in a societies which has simple social structure like rural society. Whereas organic solidarity exist in the society which has complex social structure like urban society.

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Division of Labour

What holds Society Together ?



Social Solidarity

Durkheim explained two types of Social Solidarity that exist in Society

- 1) Mechanical Solidarity
- 2) Organic Solidarity

Durkheim classified solidarity in primitive and modern societies on the basis of similarities and specialisations

According to E.D, Primitive and simple societies have Mechanical Solidarity whereas modern and complex societies have Organic Solidarity.

Mechanical Solidarity

According to “Emile Durkheim”, traditional societies or rural societies has mechanical solidarity. Individuals bond together in traditional society by the homogeneity. The division of labor is very slight in this type of society. Individual almost have similar skill sets and have similar job responsibilities. In traditional society individuals earn their livelihood from agriculture and in agriculture societies there is very low division of labor almost every individual is peasant. Moreover, people of rural society share similar religion, culture, norms, believes and values. Due to the homogeneity they are connected with one another and society, which is characterized by, “Emile Durkheim” as mechanical solidarity. Mechanical solidarity is based on the sameness of people living in a society. Emile Durkheim built an analogy which compare a society with a machine or a series of machines which are manufactured similarly. Suppose if there is a problem in a part of machine because of which machine is not working. It can be replaced by the same part of other machine and it will start working again. By this analogy Durkheim was trying to prove that, traditional or rural societies are held together by homogeneity.

Organic solidarity

Emile Durkheim believed that, modern industrial societies has organic solidarity. Individuals in modern bond together by heterogeneity. In urban society division of labor is very high; every individual possess different skill set or specialization. Moreover, individuals dissimilar, religion, believes, values norm and culture. So the logic dictated question arises here that, what hold them together? The answer is interdependence. Individuals in urban society are dependent on each other because of high division of labor, they trade their skills with one another which connects them with each other. Suppose if someone need legal assistance he will hire a lawyer, if someone car is broke he will go to mechanic for repair and if someone need hair cut he will go to barber. Individuals in urban society rely on each other that is what unify them. Emile Durkheim compared modern societies with organism, which are composed of multiple organ and each organ has its specialized function, organism is healthy if each part or organ perform its function. Similarly, modern society are composed of multiple institutions and each has its own specialized function if each individual and institution perform its function then it will result in healthy society.

Difference between Organic and mechanical solidarity

Mechanical Solidarity

Mechanical solidarity is a result of similarities between members of a society.

Seen in Traditional societies.

Minimum division of Labor

Less specialisation of task.

Everyone has to perform various tasks.

Less interdependence.

Organic Solidarity

Organic solidarity is a result of the interdependence among members of a society.

Seen in modern societies.

Complex division of Labor.

More specialisation of task.

Everyone performs a specific task.

More interdependence